



Simple Past VS Past Continuous

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Quick Reminder

- **Past Continuous** (was/were + verb-ing) = longer / background action
- **Simple Past** = shorter / completed action that interrupted or happened during the longer action

Exercise 1: Complete the sentences with the correct form (Simple Past or Past Continuous).

1. While I _____ (walk) to the park, I _____ (see) an old friend.
2. She _____ (cook) dinner when the phone _____ (ring).
3. They _____ (play) football when it suddenly _____ (start) to rain.
4. I _____ (watch) TV when my brother _____ (come) home.
5. He _____ (read) a book while she _____ (write) a letter.
6. We _____ (have) dinner when the power _____ (go) out.
7. The students _____ (study) quietly when the fire alarm _____ (go) off.
8. I _____ (not / hear) the doorbell because I _____ (listen) to loud music.
9. She _____ (fall) asleep while she _____ (read) a book.
10. The cat _____ (chase) a mouse when it _____ (run) into a hole.

Exercise 2: Choose the correct form.

1. I _____ when the phone rang.
(a) slept (b) was sleeping (c) sleep
2. She _____ when I called her.
(a) cooked (b) was cooking (c) cooks
3. They _____ football when it started to rain.
(a) played (b) were playing (c) play

4. He _____ his homework when his friend arrived.
(a) did (b) was doing (c) does
_____.
5. While we _____ dinner, the lights went out.
(a) ate (b) were eating (c) eat
_____.
6. I _____ TV when my mom came home.
(a) watched (b) was watching (c) watches
_____.
7. She _____ the bus when she saw an accident.
(a) took (b) was taking (c) takes
_____.
8. They _____ a movie when the power went out.
(a) watched (b) were watching (c) watch
_____.
9. He _____ in the garden when it started to rain.
(a) worked (b) was working (c) works
_____.
10. I _____ breakfast when the doorbell rang.
(a) ate (b) was eating (c) eat
_____.
5. (celebrating / we / were / when / it / started / raining) →
_____.
6. (ate / breakfast / he / before / he / went / jogging) →
_____.
7. (watched / we / a / movie / when / the / power / went / out) →
_____.
8. (baking / she / was / cookies / when / he / knocked / on / the / door) →
_____.
9. (already / arrived / they / at / the / airport / when / I / got / there) →
_____.
10. (painting / she / was / the / wall / when / I / saw / her) →
_____.

Exercise 3: Rearrange the words and use the correct tense.

1. (snowing / it / was / when / we / hiking) →
_____.
2. (laughing / they / were / when / he / told / the / joke) →
_____.
3. (left / she / after / he / called) →
_____.
4. (working / I / was / when / he / arrived / at / the / office) →
_____.

Exercise 4: Correct the mistakes, if any.

1. He was played soccer when it started to rain. →
_____.
2. They was studying for the exam when the power went out. →
_____.
3. I finished my homework while I was watched TV. →
_____.
4. She was read a book when the phone rang. →
_____.
5. We were going to the beach and it starting raining. →
_____.
6. He ate dinner when she was arrived. →
_____.

7. They were talked when the teacher walked in. →
_____.

8. I was taking a shower when the doorbell was rang. →
_____.

9. She was cooking dinner and then she burns her hand. →
_____.

10. We was having a picnic when the storm began. →
_____.

4. He _____ (**drive**) to the hotel when he _____ (**see**) the accident.

5. They _____ (**walk**) on the beach when it _____ (**start**) raining.

6. I _____ (**not / hear**) the announcement because I _____ (**listen**) to music.

7. While we _____ (**explore**) the city, we _____ (**get**) lost.

8. She _____ (**take**) photos when her camera _____ (**fall**) into the water.

9. The guide _____ (**tell**) stories while we _____ (**sit**) around the fire.

10. We _____ (**have**) a great time until the rain _____ (**begin**).

Exercise 5: Complete with the correct tense.

1. While I _____ (**wait**) at the airport, I _____ (**meet**) an old classmate.

2. She _____ (**read**) a book when the flight _____ (**be**) announced.

3. We _____ (**have**) dinner when the lights suddenly _____ (**go**) out.